

Study Skills

Reflective Practice

Reflective practice is an important and useful tool which will benefit you in both your professional and your academic career. In some professions is an integral and critical skill required for your Continuing Professional Development, or CPD. In other settings, it can provide a helpful framework for improving your work and supporting you to develop skills in project management, problem solving and critical analysis.

This video outlines two frameworks that you might wish to use for reflective practice. If you have questions about reflective practice, you may approach the study skills team or your module lecturer.

Using techniques of reflective practice can assist in three main areas:

The first is Professional Development. If you are fortunate enough to have appraisals or staff development meetings on an annual basis, reflective practice will help you to have meaningful discussions with your mentor or work colleague. Thinking about what worked, what areas you might wish to explore for further development, and what additional training or support you might need are all important elements of your annual review. In fact, taking a reflective approach throughout the year will help ensure that when you do put your documents together it will be much easier. For example, thinking about a project or task that didn't necessarily go to plan might highlight additional training that would be beneficial. Or, it might also highlight areas where additional support, in terms of resource for staffing, funding or time, would have helped. These are all topics that can be discussed during an appraisal or annual review.

Another is related to Self-Evaluation and Action Planning. Reflective practice will also help you to examine your own beliefs and assumptions about your work. Writing down thoughts and feelings sometimes helps you identify recurring themes or thoughts that you might not otherwise identify. For example, you may have concerns about a situation at work. Perhaps a project isn't going well. If you write about the actions you have taken and the outcomes from it, you may find that there are particular actions that have a greater impact than other actions. Without reflecting on this by writing it down and thinking about it, that information might not be as apparent. You may have beliefs or attitudes which, once identified, are not relevant in the context of the project. For example, although you feel the project is slow, you have achieved more than you had anticipated, which may help give you more confidence. Reflective practice has provided a good framework for evaluating your actions and helping to plan future actions.

A somewhat advanced approach is described as Action Research. Action planning leads to action research, an effective tool for problem-solving. Within an action research cycle, which is very similar in nature to reflective practice, the planning, evidence gathering and action are key. Becoming comfortable with a 'plan, try, monitor and evaluate' process will help to ensure you are effectively evaluating and responding to conditions within a project or set of circumstances. In action research, reflection takes place before the planning stage, which means that any reflective practice you have already undertaken will help to support the next steps.

But, now let's return to Reflective Practice. Taking the time to think carefully about what you are learning and how it applies to your work or your educational aspirations will add value to the time you spend. Reflective practice is not always easy and it may not come naturally to you, but, as with all new things, with practice you will develop reflective skills and it will become easier and perhaps even natural. It also forms part of your assessment activities, whether through portfolios, reflective journals or even discussion boards.

Generally, the key questions you will be asked to consider in this programme are:

What are you learning about?

Why is it important?

What do you know about the situation? What might you need to know?

What will it lead to?

How might you do things differently in the future?

Reflective practice should also include examples of information, evidence or actions that have influenced you. This can include thoughts or feedback from peers and teaching and professional colleagues, data from research you have carried out or have access to, information presented at meetings, teaching sessions or conferences, references to things you have read and even comments from colleagues or friends. Thinking carefully about what 'evidence' you might want to include as part of your reflective practice is also an important skill and one that may take some getting used to. Part of the reflective process is being able to identify the many ways that you might assess or measure your practice and experience, using these as a basis for further professional and personal development.

Reflective practice is not simply about recording what you did – it is about recording and thinking about what you did, what happened when you did it, what you might do differently if you were faced with the same set of circumstances and what you might do in the future based on what you have learned from the process.

The point of reflective practice is to give you the time to think carefully about what you are doing and learning and how it applies to your professional and academic practice. By practicing these reflective skills, you will add value to the time you spend studying and working. Reflective practice is not always easy and it may not come naturally to you, but, as with all new things, the more of it you do, the easier it will become.

There are a number of frameworks that you can use to support your reflective practice process. Two frameworks are outlined here, but you may find that others work better for you. If this is the case, it will be helpful to include a description of the process you plan to use as a basis for anyone who might be reading or engaging with your reflective work.

In this video, the two frameworks we will describe were proposed by Graham Gibbs and Donald A. Schon.

Both approaches are circular in structure – there isn't necessarily a beginning and an end to the process. In the Gibbs' model, you can start anywhere in the cycle and work your way around the questions.

Conceptually, it is sometimes easier to start at the 'what happened' stage, but if you wanted to begin with the 'evidence' stage, it would still allow you to work around the cycle. Schon's approach is much more

aligned to professional practice, where you might need to spend more time framing the question than identifying an issue. Whatever framework you decide to use, you should make it clear to your reader how you are working through the process of reflection and identify the framework you are using.

Reflective practice is not simply about recording what you did – it is about recording and thinking about what you did, what happened when you did it, and what you might do differently if you were faced with the same set of circumstances. It also should help you to focus on what you might do in the future, such as anticipating events or circumstances.

This simple method is very easy to use and offers a good structure for thinking about your learning and professional activities. The structure described here was designed to help ensure that ‘experience’ is included in the learning cycle. It recognises that ‘doing’ leads to learning, but that to be most effective, you have to ‘think’ about what you did. The expectation here is that learning applies to all contexts, both professional and academic, and that this model can help to ensure that your experiences inform your learning, including thinking about how you learn and what things help you to learn more effectively, such as when and where you study.

Gibbs then expanded the circular framework and called it a Personal Action Plan, to make it clearer that this process is about taking control of your own learning or professional practice, based on experience and thinking about circumstances that were both positive and negative. Although there are more ‘steps’ to this framework, the smaller steps might be easier to work with. This approach is much more aligned to achieving an ‘outcome’, but this may be what is expected of you as part of your reflective practice within your coursework.

This approach may also help you to think about reflection ‘in action’ and reflection ‘on action’. So, if you tried something and then considered and evaluated the outcomes after the event, this should impact on how you do the task in the future. For example, this works well when you consider your coursework submissions and subsequent feedback from the tutor. The feedback can help you to improve your work on the next assignment.

On the other hand, trying different things in real time and then evaluating those as you go along would be reflection ‘in action’. This means that you might do a range of activities and ‘experiment’ with them and then evaluate their outcomes to see which seemed to provide the best solution. Throughout the full process you are applying a reflective perspective, but you are also not waiting for the project to finish before making adjustments.

Schön’s work is based much more on professional practice, rather than reflective learning, but we have included it here because you may have heard it mentioned elsewhere and you find it useful in your professional practice.

In this model the ‘framing’ of the question is key, because everything follows from this. If you aren’t framing your topic appropriately, you won’t be able to gather sufficient evidence for the ‘experience’ and you won’t be able to synthesise the information correctly, re-evaluate it suitably or apply a possible outcome in the right way. Spending time on framing the question or topic is clearly as important as any of the others, so it is a good way to ensure you think carefully before you start a reflective activity.

In fact, being able to frame a question is one of the most important skills for professional practice, whether it is related to research, improving educational materials or environments or establishing a new way to do things. Thinking carefully about what you want to achieve and what limitations or opportunities there are will better prepare you for answering the question or achieving the goal.

You may find that your programme teams have identified models that they would prefer you to use, based on the discipline or subject area you are studying. Do follow this guidance – frameworks help to focus your thoughts and communicate your ideas and outcomes to others which will ultimately assist the programme teams in understanding more about you, your background, your ambitions and how they can help you to develop as an individual.

We hope this brief introduction will help you to be successful in developing your reflective practice, which is an important element of the programme. As with many things, it takes practice to master and it may seem difficult at first. But, it will also become easier to use as you use it more.